
STARTUPS



AI crawler Firecrawl raises \$14.5M, is still looking to hire agents as employees

Firecrawl's co-founder and CEO Caleb Pfeffer knew the exact moment he found the investor to lead his Series A.

He was in a coffee meeting with Nexus Venture Partner's Abhishek Sharma at the Blue Bottle in San Francisco's South Park (a favorite VC haunt). While describing the future of the company, he was gesturing so animatedly that his chair tipped



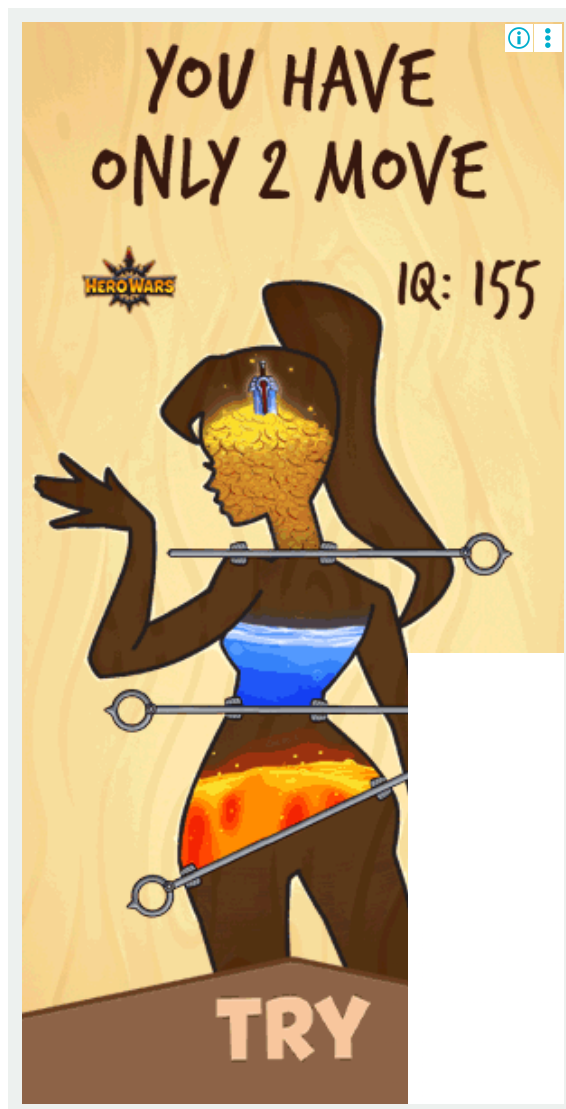
"I actually fell out of my chair. And Abhishek, as a great investor does, caught the chair and me as I was falling," Pfeffer described with a laugh. That felt like a symbol for how the founder/investor relationship is supposed to work. "I think that was a clear signal that he was the right partner."

On Tuesday, Firecrawl announced a Series A led by Nexus with participation from Shopify CEO Tobias Lütke and existing investor Y Combinator.

Firecrawl offers a popular open-source web crawler for developers and AI agents, with a commercially supported version available through API. It's used by 350,000 developers, has nearly [50,000 stars](#) on GitHub and its notable customers include Shopify, Replit, and Zapier as well as "some of the largest hedge funds in the world," Pfeffer told TechCrunch. And, he says, the company is already profitable.

The startup also just released an API that supports search and will soon add support for natural language prompts, as co-founder and CTO Nicolas Silberstein Camara noted.

Pfeffer, who co-founded Firecrawl in 2022 with Camara and CMO Eric Ciarla, said gaining Lütke as an investor was "the best kind of validation."



TECH DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- HR giant Workday says hackers stole personal data in recent

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

They landed him through a gutsy email after discovering the Shopify founder had signed up to try their product through their self-service portal.

"We saw his email come in," Peffer said. The Firecrawl crew immediately emailed him to welcome him as a customer, but got no response. Two months later, some Shopify folks contacted Firecrawl for an enterprise contract. So Peffer took his shot and emailed Lütke again, mentioning they'd love for him to participate in their upcoming round.

This time, Lütke responded with compliments about their product. He was in.

While AI web crawlers have [a somewhat dubious reputation these days](#), mostly due to bad actors [that ignore robot.txt files](#), they are also a necessary part of the burgeoning AI world. AI trains on the web, [agents need to access web pages to perform their duties](#), and enterprises need personalized crawlers to consume their own websites for training and operations.

The Firecrawl founders also hope to help address the frustrating parts of their industry. They are working on tools to help website owners, publishers, and other content creators "get paid when AI uses their content. We think this is the way it should be," Peffer said.

While there have been lots of efforts around this idea from big names like [Adobe and Getty](#) as well as startups [like Bria](#),

breach

- How your solar rooftop became a national security issue
- A comprehensive list of 2025 tech layoffs
- Co-founder of Elon Musk's xAI departs the company
- Google CEO adds a new calendar feature at Stripe co-founder's request
- NASA has sparked a race to develop the data pipeline to Mars
- Why I finally left Spotify

Sponsored by RTB House



SPONSORED

Generative AI Is Fixing Context
Here's How

[Calliope Networks](#), and others, Peffer feels that Firecrawl has an edge because it's already working with those who are scraping data.

"We already have one side of the marketplace," he said. "What we want to do is just connect that side of the marketplace to the website owners, the publishers."

Interestingly, Firecrawl also went viral a few months ago for reasons that have little to do with their open source tool. They had posted an [ad to the YC job board looking to hire an AI agent as an employee for a \\$15,000 salary](#) – perhaps the first job ad for an agent employee, ever.

That job search didn't yield an agent worth hiring, so Firecrawled upped the budget to up [\\$1 million to hire several agents and the developers who built them, and tried again](#). Applicants flooded in, Peffer said, but the company hasn't yet hired any. The founders realized that evaluating and managing wanna-be agent employees is a job in itself. So now they are looking for an AI chief of staff.

Firecrawl's Peffer will [be on stage at Disrupt in October](#) to discuss all that he's learned in a session that covers the pros and cons of hiring AI agents as early employees.

Topics: [AI](#) [AI agents](#) [Startups](#) [TC](#) [Webcrawler](#)

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [t](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)



Julie Bort

Venture Editor | [X](#)

Julie Bort is the Startups/Venture Desk editor for TechCrunch.

...

[View Bio](#) >

———— KEEP READING ————



Eight Sleep raises \$100M to expand its AI-powered sleep tech

Kate Park — 3:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: EIGHT SLEEP / EIGHT SLEEP

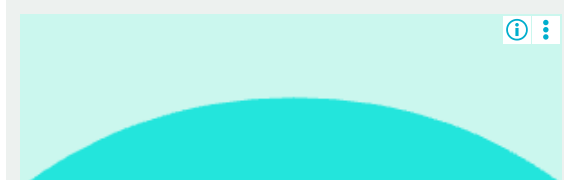
Roughly [one in three adults in the U.S. regularly gets insufficient sleep](#), driving demand for tools that can monitor, analyze, and enhance rest. [Eight Sleep](#), founded in 2014, offers AI-powered sleep tech products that promise to transform your bed into a preventive health device.

The New York-based startup announced Tuesday that it raised a fresh \$100 million round from investors such as HSG, Valor Equity Partners, Founders Fund, Y Combinator and athletes including Ferrari F1 driver Charles Leclerc, and Zak Brown, who is the CEO of McLaren F1.

With this round, Eight Sleep has raised roughly \$260 million total, Pitchbook estimates. It previously raised an \$86 million Series C in 2021 by investors who assigned it a [\\$500 million post-money valuation](#). Eight Sleep said its valuation has doubled since its last round, but didn't disclose specifics.

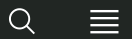
"If we successfully execute our AI roadmap, launch internationally, and develop condition-specific interventions, achieving unicorn status will naturally follow," Alexandra Zatarain, co-founder and CMO of Eight Sleep, told TechCrunch.

Eight offers smart mattresses that integrate software and AI to track and enhance sleep quality. Its flagship product, Pod, offers features like measuring sleep stages, heart rate, breathing patterns, and movement. Using these insights, it



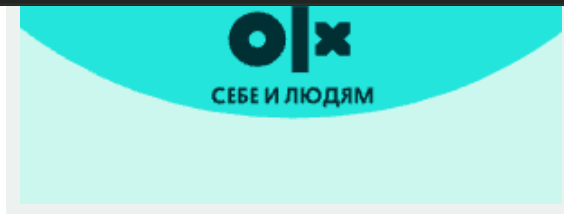
Latest
Startups
Venture
Apple

Security
AI
Apps



Events
Podcasts
Newsletters

personalized intervention, said Zatarain.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Newsletters

See More ↗

Subscribe for the industry’s biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News



Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch’s coverage.

Startups Weekly



Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review



Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

TechCrunch Mobility



TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

The sleep tech market features a range of competitors, from wearable devices such as Oura, Fitbit, and Apple, to medical-focused companies like ResMed, as well as smart mattress and sleep surface makers, including Sleep Number and ChiliSleep.

Eight’s core differentiator, Autopilot, “builds a personal blueprint from night one, then adapts continuously, accounting for seasonality, travel, stress, training, illness, or



even a bad night before. And it works independently for each side of the bed,” Zatarain said.

The startup plans to use the new funding to accelerate its growth in the medical sector, building on the Pod’s health-monitoring capabilities. With the introduction of Health Check, the system can monitor cardiovascular and respiratory patterns with up to 99% accuracy without the need for wearable devices, according to the company.

“We’re not replacing your doctor, but we are giving you nightly, high-accuracy health monitoring so you can act early if trends shift. Over time, this data can complement medical care,” Zatarain said.

Eight’s recently launched [Hot Flash Mode](#) employs AI-driven cooling to relieve menopause symptoms. It is also working on contactless solutions for sleep apnea. The company is pursuing FDA approval and will utilize the Pod’s real-time biometric monitoring to deliver personalized interventions.

Eight Sleep currently ships to over 30 countries—including Canada, the UK and EU nations, Australia, Mexico, and the UAE—and is now planning to expand into China. The CMO told TechCrunch that China, as one of the world’s largest consumer markets, is seeing a rise in a health-conscious middle class that prioritizes sleep and overall wellness.

Regarding sensitive health data, Zatarain said the company complies with each locale’s regulations, including for data storage.

“Privacy is foundational. All data is encrypted, never sold, and fully private. We comply with GDPR and CCPA, and unlike many devices, we don’t use microphones. Our biometric sensors are embedded in the bed surface — no wearables, no invasiveness, just passive, high-accuracy insights,” Zatarain said.

Topics: [AI](#) [Eight Sleep](#) [Fundraising](#) [North America](#) [sleeptech](#)

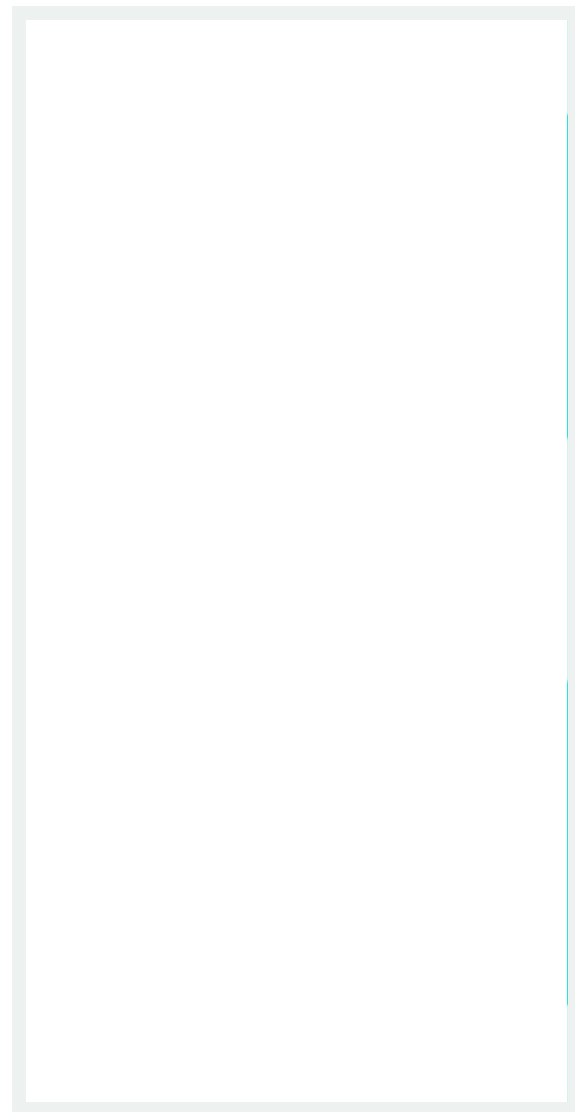
[United States](#)

No newsletters selected.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).



[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [📷](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)



Kate Park

Reporter, Asia | [X](#)

Kate Park is a reporter at TechCrunch, with a focus on technology, startups and venture capital in Asia. She previously was a financial...

[View Bio](#) >

KEEP READING



STARTUPS

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [📷](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)

Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing,” Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was actually a pain to maintain. There’s so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs.”

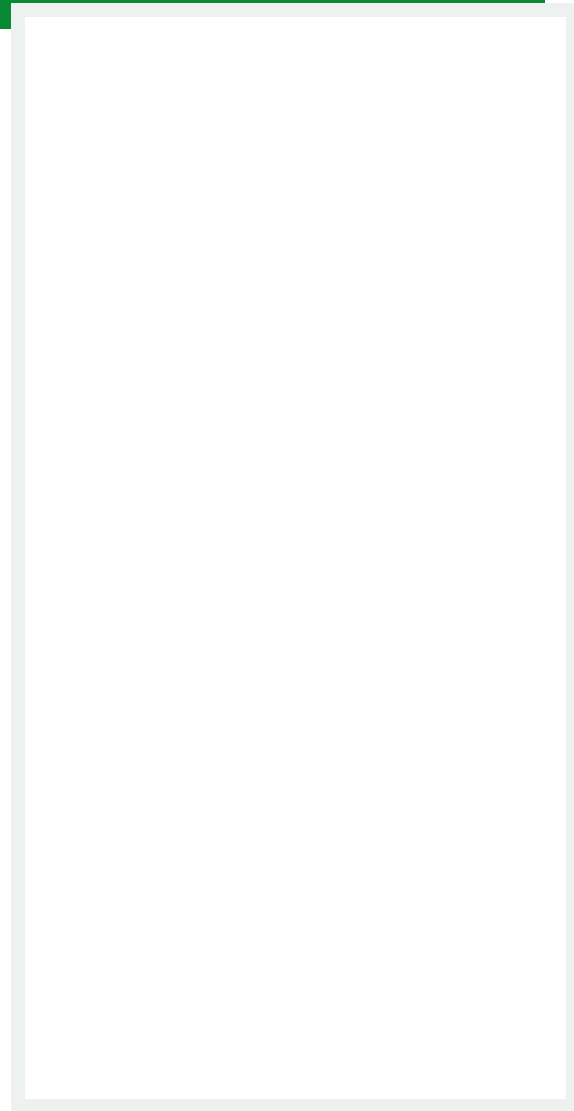
The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google’s Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

“We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs,” Monaco said. “It’s just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users.”

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company’s “extremely aggressive product roadmap.”



Latest in Startups

[See More](#)

ENTERPRISE



CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh - 2 hours ago

STARTUPS



AI crawler Firecrawl raises \$14.5M, is still looking to hire agents as employees

Julie Bort - 5 hours ago

TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT 2025



The wait is almost over: The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops August 27

Isabelle Johannessen

- 23 hours ago

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

“The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product,” Monaco said. “I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it.”

Paradigm isn't the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn't really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn't think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won't necessarily stay that way forever.

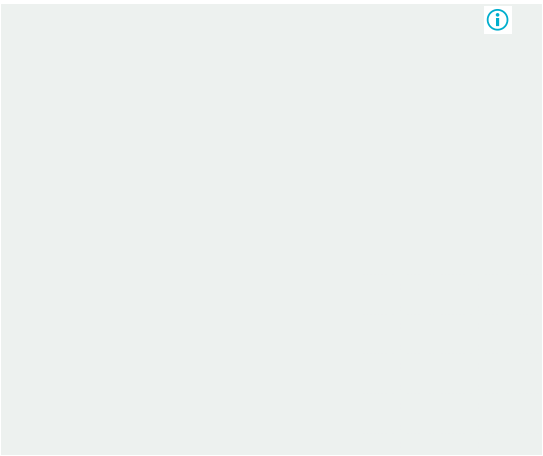
“What I'm seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That's the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

We're always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out [this survey](#) to let us know how we're doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

[enterprise startup](#) [Exclusive](#) [Fundraising](#) [fundraising](#)

[General Catalyst](#) [startup](#) [startup fundraising](#) [Startups](#)

[United States](#)



- [f](#)
- [X](#)
- [in](#)
- [reddit](#)
- [envelope](#)
- [link](#)

Rebecca Szkutak

Senior Reporter, Venture | [in](#)

Becca is a senior writer at TechCrunch that covers venture capital trends and startups. She previously covered the same beat for Forbes...

[View Bio](#) >

Loading the next article



- [X](#)
- [in](#)
- [f](#)
- [instagram](#)
- [youtube](#)
- [messenger](#)
- [@](#)



TechCrunch

Staff

Contact Us

Advertise

Crunchboard
Jobs

Site Map

Terms of
Service

Privacy Policy

RSS Terms of
Use

Neuralink

Google Chrome

StubHub

Claude

GPT-5

Tech Layoffs

ChatGPT